> out of business on each 31st March and recommences de novo on the 1st of April; and (2) The emancipation of the railway management from the control of the Finance Department. The primary function of any such department is to reduce to a minimum expenditure in order to keep at the minimum the corresponding taxation. [92]

This practice continued until 2016, when the Central government merged the Railway Budget with the Union Budget. The merger of the Railway Budget with the General Budget was based on the recommendations of the committee headed by Shri Bibek Debroy, Member, NITI Aayog, who wrote a paper on 'Dispensing with the Railway Budget' with Shri Kishore Desai. [93] The last Railway Budget was presented on 26 February 2016 by Railway Minister Suresh Prabhakar Prabhu.

ELECTRIC RAILWAYS ARRIVE

Though the process of consolidation of the railways had started in the beginning of the twentieth century, changes were not immediately evident. It took time for the railways to recover from the strain of World War I, and upgradation plans that had been drawn up at the beginning of the century were now slowly seeing the light of day.

Railway electrification was one such project.

The idea to electrify the railway network was proposed as early as 1904, by W.H. White, chief engineer of the then Bombay Presidency government. He proposed the electrification of the two Bombay-based companies, the GIP Railway and the Bombay, Baroda and Central India Railway (BB&CI Railway), now known as Central Railway and Western Railway respectively, and a joint terminus of both the railways. Both the companies were in favour of electrification, but there were differences on the idea of a joint terminus.

The Government of India appointed C.H. Merz as a consultant to give an opinion. He was the one who had designed the London Underground, the world's first electric railway, in 1890. But the project ran into trouble after Merz resigned before making any concrete suggestions. One of the only suggestions he made was to replace the existing rail bridge on the BB&CI Railway over the Vasai Creek near Bombay with a stronger one. Before his suggestions could be taken up, World War I began, delaying the bridge's reconstruction until the 1920s. By the 1920s, Merz was back, this time as a partner with his own consultancy firm. The project now moved ahead